

Malware Explained

Malware (malicious software) disrupts systems, damages data, or steals access to devices and networks. It's a common cyber attack tool that can run silently in the background, threatening both individuals and organisations.

Malware spreads through email attachments, fake downloads, infected websites, or compromised software, often paired with phishing tricks.

Types of malware

Common types include:

- Viruses: Attach to files and spread when opened
- Worms: Spread across networks automatically
- Trojans: Pretend to be legitimate software
- Ransomware: Locks files until payment is made
- Spyware: Secretly tracks your activity
- Adware: Shows unwanted ads and tracks behaviour

How it spreads

You might open a malicious file, click a bad link, or visit an infected site. Once inside, malware hides and starts stealing data, monitoring you, or disrupting your device.

The impact

Individuals face data theft, account hacks, financial loss, and slow devices.

Businesses suffer data breaches, downtime, huge costs, and reputation damage. Ransomware can stop operations completely.

Warning signs

Look for these red flags:

- Slow device performance or strange behaviour
- Frequent crashes or error messages
- Unknown programs or files appearing
- Excessive pop-ups or ads
- High network usage or data consumption
- Antivirus suddenly disabled

How to protect yourself

Stay safe with these steps:

- Avoid downloads from unknown sources
- Be cautious with email attachments and links
- Keep all software and operating systems updated
- Use trusted antivirus protection
- Back up important data regularly
- Limit admin access on your device

For businesses

Add network monitoring, strict access controls, and staff training.

Malware keeps evolving to beat security. Understanding how it works helps you stay one step ahead and keep your systems secure.